Motors and Tata Consultancy Services. His contributions to the Tata Group and the nation's industrialization were lauded and he remains the only industrialist to be conferred the Bharat Ratna, India's highest civilian award.

A fierce nationalist and a man of impeccable integrity, JRD was a 'father figure' and mentor to Ratan. Both were alike in many respects and, most notably, both had the same weakness—a virtually insatiable desire to fly.

Joining the Group

Ratan had started working with IBM on his return from the US. He would sit in the IBM office in the Vulcan Insurance Building near Churchgate. But JRD convinced him that his rightful place was with the Tata Group. Ratan says: 'I sat and typed out my CV because IBM had nice electric typewriters which no one else had at that time. I then handed over my CV to JRD; and that's how I got into Tata.' JRD wanted Ratan to begin on the shop floors of two of the group's best-run, best-managed and largest companies, the Tata Engineering and Locomotive Company (TELCO) and the Tata Iron and Steel Company (TISCO), both situated in Jamshedpur in east India. It was a way to ensure that Ratan would start with the basics.

Ratan started his assignment at TELCO on a two-week attachment with the family department. It was a key learning module that exposed him to the salient aspects of the welfare schemes of the company. It was important to understand the problems of workers and their families. After that, he moved to the engineering wing. This was more exciting for him. Chanchal Singh, a couple of years younger than Ratan, was the machine shop instructor during 1962–63. He says that when he learned that Ratan was being attached to TELCO, he thought that it would only be for a short duration and that Ratan would confine his interactions to the top management. But the young Tata behaved like any other apprentice, was very inquisitive and a keen learner. Singh remarks that with his greater enthusiasm and sharper intellect, Ratan grasped the processes much faster than any of the others.

He recalls that Ratan was very down-to-earth with no airs and mixed freely with all. This enabled him to learn more. His trainers were initially nervous at the thought of teaching the US-educated Ratan. But seeing his affable manner, they became enthusiastic about sharing their knowledge.